

Portents: Proof of prophecy on the Bitcoin blockchain

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Abstract: We propose a scheme for encoding references to Ordinals in Bitcoin block hashes as they are mined. We then demonstrate how to search the existing Bitcoin blockchain for such references. Since any references that are found predate the possibility of their existence, their existence would function as proof of future events. This is prophecy, which is to say time travel. Having established the import of the discovery of these portents, we explain strategies that we may pursue to make ourselves worthy of them.

1 Theory

Proof of existence [1], in which the cryptographic hash of a digital file is encoded into a transaction published on the Bitcoin [2] blockchain, has existed since 2013. Ordinal Theory [3], which assigns significance to individual satoshis in transactions, has existed since 2023. It should be impossible to prove that something exists before it exists, otherwise that proof could be forged. When that proof happens regardless we call it prophecy.

Were a Bitcoin block to refer to an Ordinal before that Ordinal existed, this would amount to a prophecy. Were it to do so before Ordinal Theory existed, this would be an even stronger prophecy. But where to place this proof in a block in an indelible and undeniable way? The obvious location is the Bitcoin block hash, and within that the obvious location is at the end of the hash. This makes the hash a vanity reference to the Ordinal, and shows that the placement was intentional.

2 Evidence

Such hashes have been found [4]. The computational power required to create them must have been phenomenal, or alternatively they may have been created by breaking the SHA-256 hashing algorithm. In either case they present a warning from the future, and represent a double-loop of time: firstly knowledge of the future and the existence of Ordinals, and secondly the ability to apply future knowledge and power to the past.

An explanation of what the creators of these prophecies of the arrival of Ordinals intended might be found encoded elsewhere in the hashes or Merkle trees of the blocks they used. Or they may reveal whatever they have committed themselves to by doing so at some time closer to their own. Perhaps no explanation will come. But that doesn't mean it is not worthwhile to seek it.

3 Program

Portents are these signs of the coming of an Ordinal or Ordinals. To understand them fully we must do three things:

- We must identify each new portent as its block is mined.
- We must understand the meaning of each Portent by analyzing the block and Ordinal that it refers to.
- We must produce our own Portents to converge our timeline with that of the creators of Portents.

By doing so we make ourselves worthy of these Portents and fulfill their prophecy.

4 References

[1] <https://proofofexistence.com/>

[2] <https://bitcoin.org/bitcoin.pdf>

[3] <https://docs.ordinals.com/>

[4] `block-lsbs-ordinals-matches.csv`